



## DR. HENRY KING STANFORD



**D**r. Henry King Stanford is the third president of the University of Miami and the third sponsor of Iron Arrow. He was tapped into the society on November 10, 1966, at “the old tapping tree,” and welcomed into membership by Chief Barry Richard.

I remember seeing Dr. Stanford wearing his Seminole jacket many times; at Homecoming when he would dance with the student Homecoming Queen, and again at Homecoming football games. He is a familiar figure at the head table of the tapping luncheons, and many are the faculty and alumni members of IA who have been tapped in the president’s office, where he had invited them on “important business that must be discussed in person.”

Dr. Stanford was instrumental in clearing the way for the tribe’s tapping mound and firebowl which now stand near the bookstore beneath a cool and spreading ficus tree. When the tribe proposed moving the statue of Dr. Ashe to the foyer of the Administration Building, Dr. Stanford’s help was decisive in allowing the Iron Arrow membership plaques to be placed alongside the statue.

Dr. Stanford’s contributions to Iron Arrow are many, but two, I think, are particularly important. First, it was Dr. Stanford who promoted the James Hutchinson Fund initiated by Eugene Cohen, to acquire 50 oil canvases to preserve for posterity much of the beauty and culture of the Seminole Indians. At this writing, several of these canvases hang in the Office of the President, immediately impressing upon official guests of the University the unique relationship of the





University community with the Everglades tribes. Aside from Eugene Cohen's role in establishing the fund at the University of Miami and Dr. Stanford's enthusiastic support of the project, recognition is also due John J. DuPuis, Jr., and Charlton Tebeau.

Dr. Stanford's second contribution to the Iron Arrow tradition is both gracious and popular. Each year at Homecoming, he and Mrs. Stanford host a reception for Iron Arrow members and guests in their home. This event was first held on October 27, 1971, in the old W. T. Grant mansion on South Bayshore Drive in Coconut Grove, the home of the first three presidents of the University and their families. The tradition continues and holds equal esteem in President and Mrs. Stanford's new home on Old Cutler Road near Matheson Hammock Park. I remember standing on Mrs. Stanford's sun porch with its touch of rattan-wicker decor and its profuse, vigorous assortment of tropical flora and looking out over a lawn alive with the thousand colors and patterns of Seminole jackets. On such warm autumn nights, the quiet elegance of times long past come to mind with every foliage-scented breath, and 1926, seems no further away than the shadows surrounding the lawn.





## 1968-1976 - THE MICCO YEARS



In the later years of the 1960s, an era was coming to a close in Iron Arrow. Continued external assault upon the tribe by rejected aspirants surfaced as Hurricane headlines against “the ball.” The retirement of Thurston “Doc” Adams as Director of Student Activities was imminent. With Doc would go nearly two decades of experience upon which the tribe had grown dependent. And Doc left no heir-apparent.

Further difficulties appeared in the changing nature of the student body itself. Drugs became a campus phenomenon, even among many students in leadership positions. The violence of a never-ending war in Vietnam began to push more and more citizens to the brink; many campuses boiled in violent disruption. And certain elements of the UM administration apparently lost all interest in the traditional sectors of student endeavor: sectors like Homecoming and Carni Gras, Men’s Residence Halls Association, and Associated Women Students, Inter-fraternity Council and Pan-Hellenic; even Iron Arrow and Omicron Delta Kappa.

The threat was not so clearly in focus at the time: Iron Arrow was about to embark without a rudder into a turbulence unmatched in such a concentrated span of time. There were selection meetings in those years in which it was wondered if there would be anyone even eligible to tap, much less desirable. But leaders were tapped, and it now seems that this whole period only served to forge a stronger, more permanent place for the Arrow.





The society's survival was largely due to two factors: one was the concerted actions of a small group of student members who would bridge the transition from the era of Doc Adams. Among these last tappees from the Thurston Adams years were John Leatherwood, Martin Arostegui, Michael Tryson, Michael Leone, Stephen Hill, Thad Koch, Tim Choate, Steve Haas and the author.

The second factor which ultimately worked to strengthen the tribe during this critical period was the appearance and domination of the longest-reigning Chiefs in the history of the tribe. John Leatherwood alone served three years. Rhea Warren and John Benedict served two years each. Seven years among them in the position of Chief provided a continuity which was not forthcoming in any other way. Hence, the name, "the Micco years." What follows is a challenge-response history of that time.

**B**ecause Doc had always been there, the continuity of Iron Arrow was





## THE RITUAL

taken for granted. When Doc left, those who had depended on him looked around and saw they would have to formalize the tribe's customs if it were to survive effectively without him. Unwritten traditions, gradual and accumulated revisions, and word-of-mouth experiences were all in danger of disappearing quickly and irretrievably.

First in danger was the initiation ritual. Small improvements had been made several times over the years, a revised printed version having been drawn up by Barry Scott Richard, Chief, 1966-67. The initiation for most of these many years had been held on campus, around Lake Osceola, the trips to the wilderness areas occurring only as a finale to the initiation; a finale devised more for "hazing" new members than for examining the elements and significance of leadership.

With the appearance of the 960 and 1968 dorms on the shores of Lake Osceola in 1967 and 1968, the need to move the entire ceremony into the Everglades became increasingly apparent. In addition, there was some dissatisfaction with both the physical "hazing" activities in the initiation and with the comparatively shallow Seminole or Indian perspectives in much of the ceremony. The need to move the ceremony into the Everglades offered the opportunity to draw more heavily upon the relationship of the Florida wilderness to the history and ideals of Iron Arrow.

In September or October of 1968, Medicine Man Mike Tryson had come into possession of a short newspaper clipping which briefly outlined the shape and skeletal symbolism of the Seminole Wheel of Life.<sup>112</sup> The idea that the Wheel of Life could somehow be incorporated into the ritual was stored away and left to germinate.

Winter passed and in February 1969, I boarded a Delta Airlines jet bound for an ODK Province Convention in Columbia, South Carolina. The Wheel of Life was born in the first 30 minutes of that morning flight. After takeoff from Miami International, I remember looking out the window at the Everglades below and beginning to write. I also remember I was writing very quickly. The scene I was describing was a wilderness area that Thad Koch had shown to me several weeks earlier. We had seen the area in the daytime, however, and as I wrote I tried to picture it at night with a council fire and the Wheel of Life painted on the earth. I tried to smell the forest and hear the mosquitoes as I wrote. By the time the flight had landed in Atlanta, the Wheel of Life portion of the ritual was finished.

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<sup>112</sup> A James Hutchinson canvas depicts the Seminole Wheel of Life as drawn by Medicine Man Gotch Nagoftee, Josie Billie.

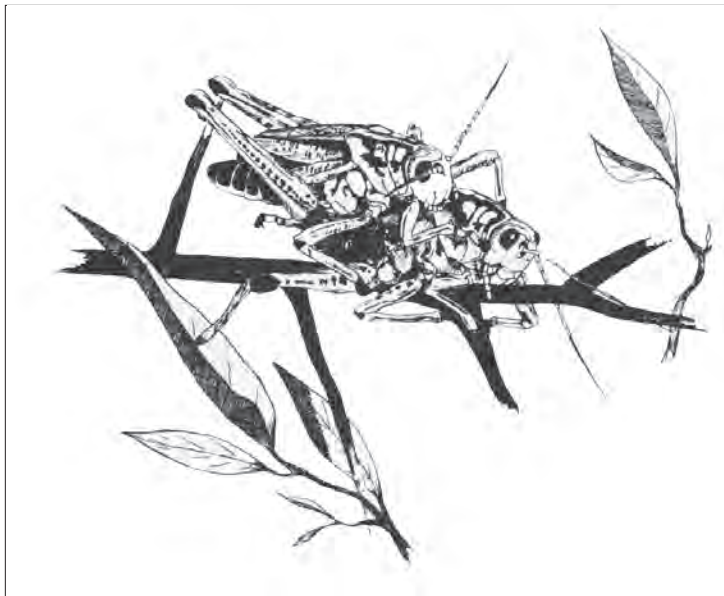




The addition of the Lessons in the Wilderness to the existing ritual occurred later that same spring, after the spring initiation. In this case, the words did not tumble quickly or easily onto the paper as they had done for the Wheel of Life. In fact, I remember laboring over a part of it for some time one evening in an apartment in South Miami belonging to Iron Arrow member Steven Haas. When the Wheel of Life had been tried in that spring initiation, it had been favorably received, but had created an unexpected time imbalance which I undertook to resolve. William Vaught, Associate Director of Student Activities (and longtime member of Iron Arrow), discussed with me the use of symbolism in the initiation ceremonies of Greek and Professional Societies of which he was a member. Fascinated by this idea, I set about reading several books on Indian cultures in North America, including two or three on the Seminoles and their language. The result this time was the Lessons in the Wilderness.

The reader may be interested to know that part of this portion of the ritual were written with specific members of the tribe in physical mind; members who reflected differing styles of leadership. It was inevitable, perhaps, that some part of the Seminole language would be put to unofficial use as a result of this undertaking. Member Ted Peck, who was Chairman of the 1968 Carni Gras, can attest to such uses personally: for years he has been known at tribal functions as Empeshaw, the Seminole word for stomach.

In the same way the flow of events challenged us to uniquely sudden adaptations in the ritual, so too they bore down fiercely on the very constitutional structure of the tribe itself. With Doc's retirement, many of the perspectives of





## THE BALL

gradual change and continuity that he had retained left with him. The need was apparent to John Leatherwood and others that what had been our customary operating procedure had to be codified and incorporated into the governing charter of the tribe.

If this need were apparent, the action to accommodate it was prompted even more forcefully by external events beginning to buffet the tribe. Outraged aspirants whose ambitions went unfulfilled launched repeated, rather spectacular assaults upon the tribe itself, and especially on the “one-ball” system.

Hurricane headlines, columns and editorials all screamed criticism of any organization with selective membership procedures, social or honorary. Measures had to be taken to lift the selection process above all reproach, real or imagined. This objective was one of the first pursued by John Leatherwood in 1969.

The problem was to provide a strict constitutional selection procedure to remove any possibility of a political misuse of the “ball”, while retaining the founding principle of unanimity and preventing a decline in the standards required for Iron Arrow membership. The procedures eventually recommended and adopted did much to quell the storms without, though they came perilously close to becoming a “two-ball” system. Nevertheless, the potential for a political or personal grudge exercise of the negative vote was set aside forever.

The second outcome of this constitutional revision was a redefinition of the duties of the tribal officers in more pragmatic terms. The Chief was given responsibility for the coordination of all tribal activities, but was also assigned specific responsibility for the tapping luncheons and their arrangements. The Son of Chief was designated coordination responsibilities for the selection and tapping of new members. The initiation ritual and the subsequent breakfast were specified as the administrative domain of the Medicine Man.

At the time these advances were being made, the tribe began to gather renewed notoriety and respect. This was partly a result of adjusted selection procedures, but in greater part, was due to the dramatic personality of one Chief and the extensive public-relations emphasis of another.

During his unprecedented three terms as Chief, John Leatherwood’s audacious representation of the tribe and all its traditions created an aura of theatric prestige that soon surrounded Iron Arrow with a sense of its own majesty. Though





## INCREASING VISIBILITY

not without controversy, Leatherwood's imperious manner attracted a kind of awe-struck attention to the power of the Iron Arrow tradition. His repeated elections to the position of Chief pay tribute more to his overpowering sense of presence on the campus stage than to considerations of platform or program.

In an administrative vacuum, John Leatherwood became a bastion of continuity for the tribe: a stubborn rudder for the turbulent period in which he served. His greatest contribution was the increased visibility and stability he brought to the tribe at a time when such qualities were desperately needed.

Other members were also contributing to the newly acquired momentum. Chief Rhea Warren and Medicine Man Steve Hill were both environmentally oriented. Under Warren's guidance, column after column of local newsprint was devoted to Iron Arrow and its activities. He was also the most effective fund-raiser for Iron Arrow activities that the tribe had ever known. If the society's accomplishments were grandiose during this period, they were also expensive. Warren's efforts at raising funds were made easier, however, by the interest and generosity of such members as Thomas Kearns, Walter Etling, Eddie Dunn, Julian Cole, Joe Shaw, Milton Weiss, Frank Smathers, Maurice Ferre, Stitch Van, John Gale, Gerald Kogan, Stanley Arkin, Freddie Berens, Phil Kaplan, Don Mariutto, Ed Rubinoff, Marshal Rosenberg, Neil Schiff, Clarence Pahnke, Tom Lee, Jose Bared and many others. It was also Warren who named Medicine Man Steve Hill as the chairman of the first Iron Arrow spring outing to Pigeon Key - one of the most popular and successful of tribal traditions in the 1970's.

